Russia-Ukraine talks likely to continue

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【メール原文】

US-mediated Russia-Ukraine talks in Abu Dhabi produced only a prisoner-exchange agreement, but the process didn't collapse. Talks will likely resume b||||||||||||||||

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Russia-Ukraine talks likely to resume before year-end

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What Happened

Two days of US-mediated Russia-Ukraine talks in Abu Dhabi, the first since February, ended on 11 November with an agreement on a prisoner-of-war exchange but no movement on core issues. US envoy Jared Kushner billed the swap as the largest of the war; numbers are still being finalized.

Our Take

The process will likely resume before year-end. Neither side wants to alienate Washington. Moscow wants to keep the US engaged while separating Ukraine from bilateral cooperation. So far, US commercial offers have not shifted Moscow’s position. Kyiv cannot afford to appear to walk away. Ukrainian reticence, Ukrainian negotiator David Arakhamia's talk of "good momentum," and Russian delegation head Vladimir Medinsky's claim of mutual understanding on some issues are vague signs of progress.

President Vladimir Putin is in no hurry. He still aims to subdue Ukraine and sees no reason to rush to a deal while US pressure on Moscow is almost non-existent. Kyiv's main fear is the opposite imbalance: that Washington will instead press Ukraine to make concessions. The Kremlin’s demands remain sweeping , as it wants a wider security agreement with NATO and Europe, the “demilitarization” of Ukraine, a change of the current leadership, and de jure acceptance of the annexation of the occupied territories.

Fundamental gaps remain on territory, ceasefire sequencing, and other issues. Moscow rejects a ceasefire until territory and security questions are settled, while Kyiv wants one first. Despite Kyiv's push, the talks produced no maritime or energy truce. A further round may yield understandings on post-ceasefire arrangements, but is unlikely to yield understandings on territory, Ukraine's military security, or the ceasefire itself.

The two delegations also signaled different intentions. Ukraine sent political decision-makers. Russia sent generals, intelligence officers, and two deputy foreign ministers under Vladimir Medinsky, Putin's culture adviser, mandated to relay positions but not decide anything. The absence of Yuri Ushakov, Putin's foreign policy adviser, who shapes policy more than Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov, is telling. European officials in Abu Dhabi consulted the Ukrainians but held no talks with the Russians.

What's next: Kushner and US special envoy Steve Witkoff will brief Putin in Moscow on 12 November and then meet President Volodymyr Zelensky in Dublin. The prisoner exchange is due within two to three weeks. Kyiv wants Europe to name a negotiator at the coalition of the willing meeting on 19 November and to make the next round multilateral, which Moscow opposes. The best realistic outcome is an announcement of further talks before year-end.

No change to our outlook. Eurasia Group continues to believe both sides will continue to escalate their military campaigns through the end of the first quarter of next year, after which the odds of a cease-fire will increase to 35% from 10% at present.

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